

Service request management ITIL® 4 Practice Guide

[AXELOS.com](https://www.axelos.com)

Contents

1	About this document	3
2	General information	4
3	Value streams and processes	10
4	Organizations and people	15
5	Information and technology	18
6	Partners and suppliers	20
7	Important reminder	21
8	Acknowledgments	22

1 About this document

This document provides practical guidance for the service request management practice. It is split into five main sections, covering:

- general information about the practice
- the practice's processes and activities and their roles in the service value chain
- the organizations and people involved in the practice
- the information and technology supporting the practice
- considerations for partners and suppliers for the practice.

1.1 ITIL® 4 QUALIFICATION SCHEME

Selected content from this document is examinable as a part of the following syllabuses:

- **ITIL Specialist** Create, Deliver and Support
- **ITIL Specialist** High-velocity IT.

Please refer to the respective syllabus documents for details.

2 General information

2.1 PURPOSE AND DESCRIPTION

Key message

The purpose of the service request management practice is to support the agreed quality of a service by handling all predefined, user-initiated service requests in an effective and user-friendly manner.

Definition: Service request

A request from a user or a user's authorized representative that initiates a service action which has been agreed as a normal part of service delivery.

Service requests are an important type of user query and an important part of the user experience. Typically, service requests include the following:

- a request initiating a service action (performed by the service provider or jointly with the user)
- a request for information
- a request for access to a resource or service
- feedback, compliments, or complaints.

Fulfilling service requests may include changes to services or their components; these are usually standard changes. As service requests are predefined and pre-agreed as a normal part of service delivery, they can usually be formalized with a clear, standard procedures for initiation, approval, fulfilment, and management. Some service requests have very simple workflows, such as a request for information. Other service requests, such as the setup of a new employee, may be complex and require contributions from many teams and systems in order for it to be fulfilled. Regardless of the complexity, the steps to fulfil the request should be well-known and tested. This allows the service provider to agree times for fulfilment and provide clear communication of the status of the request to users.

The development and testing of the procedures are performed at the respective stages of the product and service lifecycle and involve multiple practices, such as the business analysis, service design, risk management, change enablement, service catalogue management, and service level management practices, among others.

Some service requests require authorization, according to financial, information security, or other policies. In order to handle this appropriately, the service request management practice should follow these guidelines:

- service requests and their fulfilment should be standardized and automated as far as possible
- policies should be established depending on which service requests can be fulfilled with limited or no additional approvals to streamline fulfilment
- user expectations regarding fulfilment times should be clearly set based on what the organization can deliver
- opportunities for improvement should be identified and implemented to produce faster fulfilment times and leverage automation
- policies and workflows should be included for documenting and redirecting any requests that are submitted as service requests, but which should be managed as incidents or changes.

Some service requests can be completely fulfilled by automation, from submission to closure, allowing for a complete self-service experience. For example, client software installation or the provision of virtual servers.

2.2 TERMS AND CONCEPTS

The main characteristics of a service request includes the following:

- It is initiated by a user or a user representative.
- It requires an action from the service provider.
- It is an action that has an agreed upon service outcome. This means the service outcome was tested in advance, the approval flow and fulfilment flow for the request were pre-approved, people were trained, and service components were setup to fulfil it.

A service request is a normal part of service delivery, which is ‘business as usual’. This means the results and the timelines are well understood by the customer, users, and operation teams of the service provider, and are usually predictable. Wherever possible, service requests should be automated and accessible through channels that are efficient and convenient for users, such as a client portal.

Service requests may play different roles within service quality and service experience. In many cases, they contribute to service utility when service actions are a key form of service interaction. In some cases, service requests can add to higher service levels, adding valuable options to otherwise standardized service offerings. Finally, service requests may be used to initiate the maintenance of service components, where the service provider’s monitoring and event management capability is limited and the monitoring of service components is delegated to users.

Note that service requests are a form of user query and a way to initiate certain predefined activities significant to service experience. The same activities may be initiated differently, and although technical operations may be identical, their role in the user experience would be different, as shown in Table 2.1.

Table 2.1 Activities related to the service request practice described in other practice guides

Example	Activity	Practice guide
A user monitors status of a printer. When the printer signals ‘low toner’, the user requests toner refill. The service provider’s technician replaces the toner cartridge. Except for the replacement procedure, printing is not interrupted.	Service request	Service desk Service request management Infrastructure and platform management
A printer communicates its status and events to the operations team. When a ‘low toner’ event occurs, the service provider’s technician replaces the toner cartridge. Except for the replacement procedure, printing is not interrupted.	Event	Monitoring and event management Infrastructure and platform management
In the case of something going wrong in the above scenarios. The ‘low toner’ status is not reported in time (or the cartridge is not replaced in time or replaced incorrectly). The printing is interrupted. Users report the situation to the service provider. The service provider’s technician replaces the toner cartridge. Printing is restored.	Incident	Service desk Incident management Infrastructure and platform management

Similarly, service requests may initiate changes, which are usually standard changes but can sometimes be a normal change. The need for change is defined by the change typology adopted by the company; there is mandatory ‘correlation between service requests and changes. For example,

moving an employee from one desk to another within the office is likely to be managed as a service request; whether it needs a change or multiple changes, depends on technical impact of the move and criteria for changes agreed in the organization (as part of the change enablement practice). Some service requests of this type may need one or more changes; others would be fulfilled without the change enablement practice involved.

The lifecycle of a service request always involves multiple practices. A typical value stream to fulfil a service request is likely to involve:

- service desk: to process the user query
- service request management: to route and guide the request fulfilment
- infrastructure and platform management: to perform the necessary technical operations
- release management: to make the service components available to users
- change enablement: to coordinate the necessary changes
- information security management: to provide or alter access.

Other practices may be involved, as needed. The involvement and procedure for fulfilling every type of service request is documented in the service request models.

Definition: Service request model

A repeatable predefined approach to the fulfilment of a particular type of service requests.

Service request models are usually produced during product and service design. The models are tested and deployed to operations along with other components of the service. The service request management practice is involved at all stages to ensure that the models are realistic and accepted by everyone involved in their management and execution. The continual improvement of products and services may include the improvement of the related service request models.

Service request models describe the conditions and procedures for service request fulfilment, covering all four dimensions of service management:

- procedures and workflows, including possible options and decisions
- roles and teams responsible (usually as a RACI matrix)
- automation and tools used
- third parties involved in and supporting agreements.

As service requests are initiated by users or their representatives, they should be available to users in a convenient and actionable way. The most common approach is to include the available service requests in user-facing views of the organization's service catalogue. Management of the catalogue is within the scope of the service catalogue management practice, but information for it is provided by the service request management practice.

Definition: Request catalogue

A view of the service catalogue, providing details on service requests for existing and new services, which is made available to the user.

Usually, the following information about the available service requests is available through a request catalogue:

- service to which a service request belongs
- prerequisites/conditions for a service request invitation
- information required to initiate the request
- approval workflow, if applicable
- target fulfilment time
- other relevant information.

The service request catalogue view is expected to be tailored for service level agreements (SLAs) that are applicable to the user accessing the view, so that all of the information reflects the conditions and targets agreed for the user. The more relevant the information in the request catalogue is, the more efficient the service request fulfilment will be, and the higher the user satisfaction.

2.3 SCOPE

The scope of the service request management practice includes:

- managing service request models
- processing service requests submitted by users or their representatives
- managing the fulfilment of service requests according to the agreed models
- reviewing and continually improving request processing and fulfilment performance.

There are several activities and areas of responsibilities that are not included in the service request management practice, although they are closely related to service request management. They are listed in Table 2.2, along with references to the practices in which they can be found. It is important to remember that ITIL practices are tools to use in the context of the value streams; they should be combined as necessary, depending on the situation.

Table 2.2 Activities related to the service request management practice described in other practice guides

Activity	Practice guide
Resolving incidents	Incident management
Communicating with users	Service desk
Management and realization of changes to products and services	Change enablement Deployment management Release management
Monitoring services and technology	Monitoring and event management
Ongoing management and implementation of improvements	Continual improvement
Management of request catalogue	Service catalogue management
Management and provision of access to services	Information security management
Creating service request models	Service design

2.4 PRACTICE SUCCESS FACTORS

Definition: Practice success factor

A complex functional component of a practice that is required for the practice to fulfil its purpose.

A practice success factor (PSF) is more than a task or activity as it includes components from all four dimensions of service management. The nature of the activities and resources of PSFs within a practice may differ, but together they ensure that the practice is effective.

The service request management practice includes the following PSFs:

- ensuring that the service request fulfilment procedures for all services are optimized
- ensuring that all service requests are fulfilled according to the agreed procedures and to user satisfaction.

2.4.1 Ensuring that the service request fulfilment procedures for all services are optimized

The development of the service request procedures should be integrated early into the product and service lifecycle management. The service request practice should contribute to business analysis, architecture management, and service design activities. Depending on the decisions that are made at those stages, a service may be optimized for a no-request operation or include multiple requests available to users as a part of normal consumption. In the first case, generic requests, such as compliments, complaints, or how-to requests are still available to service users. In the second case, there may be various requests specific to service utility (their fulfilment becomes an important contributor to service quality). Service requests can also be a differentiator between different levels of service offerings (more requests may be available to users of higher trims of the service).

It is important to identify, document, and test service request fulfilment procedures and assign responsibilities for the activities. It is equally important to ensure that requests are correctly described in a request catalogue and that the catalogue is available to the users who should be able to initiate the requests. This is achieved in conjunction with the service catalogue management practice.

Service request fulfilment procedures should be subject to continual improvement based on the monitoring of fulfilment performance and user satisfaction. One way to optimize the fulfilment procedures is to automate them wherever reasonably possible. This applies to the most popular and routine requests that have limited variations in fulfilment workflows. Tailored, complex, and rare requests should be automated only after careful consideration to ensure that the costs and risks of automation are justified.

Service request fulfilment procedures are documented within the service request models, along with resources, responsibilities, and other relevant information.

2.4.2 Ensuring that all service requests are fulfilled according to the agreed procedures and to user satisfaction

If the fulfilment procedures are optimized and documented, and responsibilities are clear, service requests are easy to fulfil and plan for. Statistics on every type of request can help to optimize resource planning and to ensure the timely processing of all requests. Unlike incidents, service requests do not need to be fulfilled urgently; they allow for more comfortable planning and should be completed within an agreed timeframe.

Requests may require a review after fulfilment. The review can be limited to a satisfaction survey or include a detailed internal review (usually necessary if something went wrong, or user satisfaction is low).

2.5 KEY METRICS

The effectiveness and performance of the ITIL practices should be assessed within the context of the value streams to which each practice contributes. As with the performance of any tool, the practice's performance can only be assessed within the context of its application. However, tools can differ greatly in design and quality, and these differences define a tool's potential or capability to be effective when used according to its purpose. Further guidance on metrics, key performance indicators (KPIs), and other techniques that can help with this can be found in the measurement and reporting practice guide.

Key metrics for the service request management practice are mapped to its PSFs. They can be used as KPIs in the context of value streams to assess the contribution of the service request practice to the effectiveness and efficiency of those value streams. Some examples of key metrics are given in Table 2.3.

Table 2.3 Examples of key metrics for the practice success factors

Practice success factors	Key metrics
Ensuring that the service request fulfilment procedures for all services are optimized	Completeness of the service request catalogue, number, and percentage of service requests that are not supported with fulfilment procedures
	Number and percentage of service requests that could not be fulfilled by following the agreed procedure due to errors/inefficiencies in the procedure
	Satisfaction of the team members fulfilling the requests with instructions provided
	Average time and cost needed to fulfil requests (by types/models)
	Percentage of service requests with fully or largely automated fulfilment (number, percentage in the catalogue, percentage in total number, and fulfilment time)
Ensuring that all service requests are fulfilled according to the agreed procedures and to user satisfaction	Number and percentage of requests fulfilled according to the SLA
	Impact of incidents caused by the incorrect fulfilment of service requests
	User satisfaction with request fulfilment
	Number and percentage of requests fulfilled with deviations from the agreed procedures

The correct aggregation of metrics into complex indicators will make them easier to use for the ongoing management of value streams and for the periodic assessment and continual improvement of the service request management practice. There is no single best solution. Metrics will be based on the overall service strategy and priorities of an organization, as well as on the goals of the value streams to which the practice contributes.

3 Value streams and processes

3.1 VALUE STREAM CONTRIBUTION

Like any other ITIL management practice, the service request practice contributes to multiple value streams. It is important to remember that a value stream is never formed from a single practice. The service request practice combines with other practices to provide high-quality services to consumers. The main value chain activities to which the practice contributes are:

- engage
- deliver and support
- design and transition
- obtain/build.

The contribution of the service request management practice to the service value chain is shown in Figure 3.1.

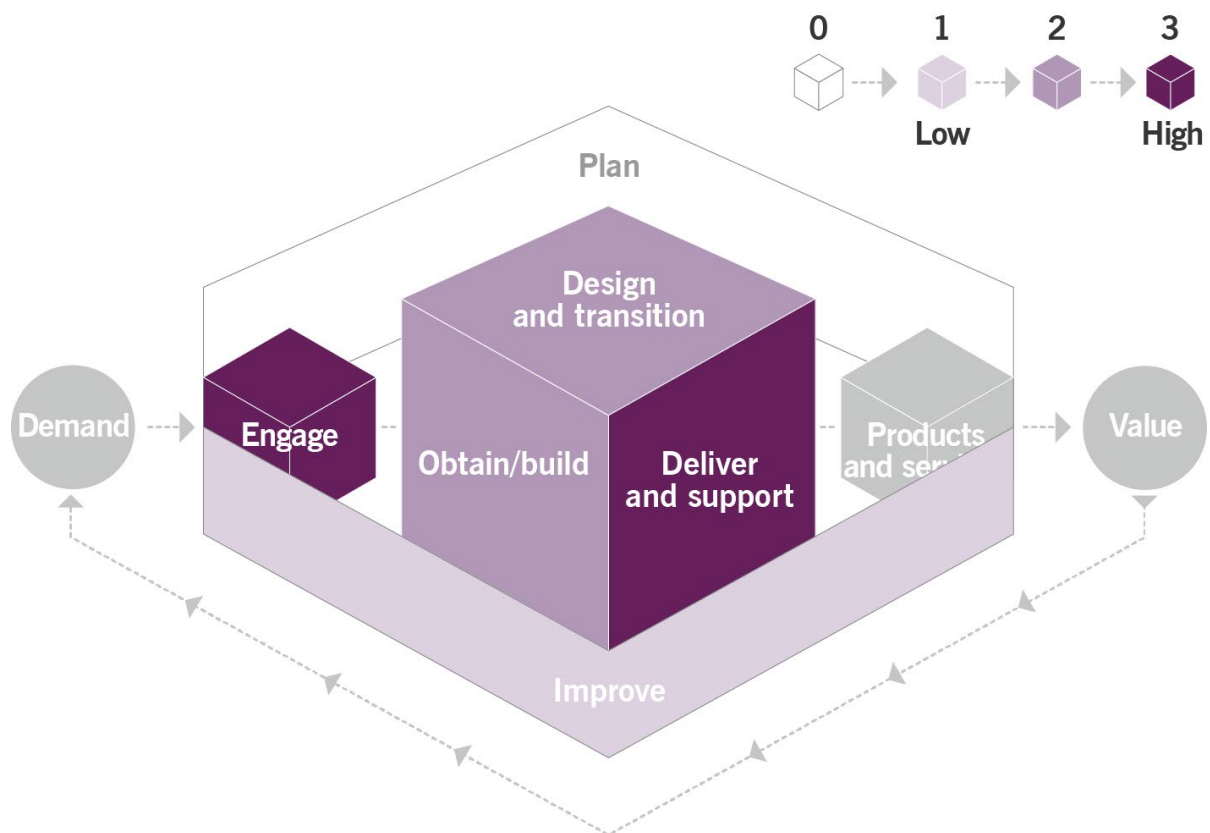


Figure 3.1 Heat map of the contribution of the service request management practice to value chain activities

3.2 PROCESSES

Each practice may include one or more processes and activities that may be necessary to fulfil the purpose of that practice.

Definition: Process

A set of interrelated or interacting activities that transform inputs into outputs. A process takes one or more defined inputs and turns them into defined outputs. Processes define the sequence of actions and their dependencies.

Service request management activities form two processes:

- service request fulfilment control
- service request review and optimization.

3.2.1 Service request fulfilment control

This process includes the activities listed in Table 3.1 and transforms the inputs into outputs.

Table 3.1 Inputs, activities, and outputs of the service request fulfilment control process

Key inputs	Activities	Key outputs
Service request queries	Request categorization	Fulfilled service requests
Service request models	Service request model initiation and control	Fulfilment actions records and reports
Service level agreements	Ad hoc fulfilment control	User satisfaction surveys
Fulfilment actions records and reports	Fulfilment review	

Figure 3.2 shows a workflow diagram of the process.

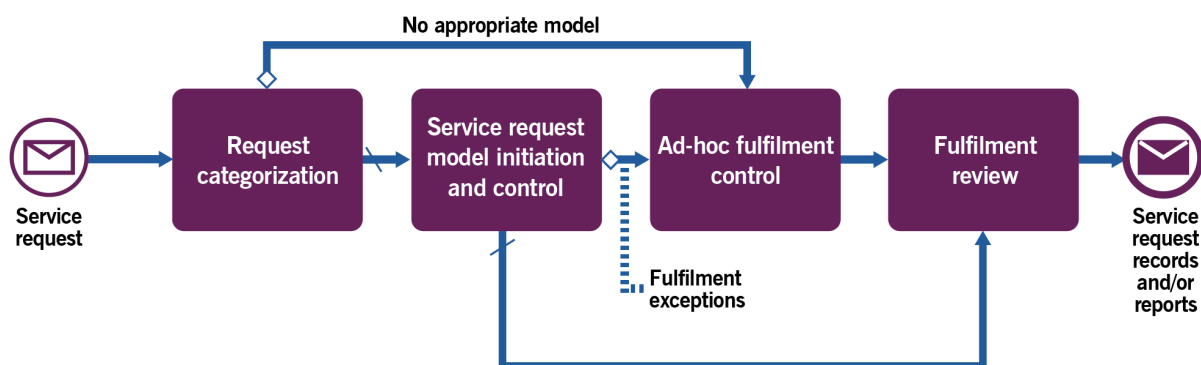


Figure 3.2 Workflow of the service request fulfilment control process

The process may vary depending on the request model. Table 3.2 provides an example of variations.

Table 3.2 Service request fulfilment control process activities

Activity	Manual or incomplete service request model	Highly automated service request model
Request categorization	All the prerequisites for the service request and user eligibility are checked, wholly or partly manually. Missing information or paperwork is requested from the user. The service desk agent chooses the appropriate service request model.	In a highly automated environment, a service request is automatically checked for all the prerequisites. If additional information or paperwork is needed, the system contacts the user and asks for the missing prerequisites. An appropriate model and set of automated procedures are chosen based on the service request characteristics.
Service request model initiation and control	The service desk agent may need to manually select the right support team or specialists, according to the service request model. The assigned teams follow the service request fulfilment procedures defined for the model. If necessary, additional approvals are obtained, according to the service request procedures. In some cases, several service request tasks need to be fulfilled. Manual assignment and control by the service desk agent is needed, as well as notifications to the user. Responsible teams fulfil whole service request or specific tasks. If necessary, the responsible team updates the relevant configuration items. Upon fulfilment, the service request is routed to the fulfilment review.	Request fulfilment according to the chosen service request model is initiated and the system controls the flow of procedures and scripts evoked to fulfil the request. Upon fulfilment, the service request is routed to the fulfilment review.
Ad hoc fulfilment control	There are cases when a service request fulfilment needs some non-standard, tailored work, or there are some new circumstances that were not taken into consideration when the service request was planned. So following the procedure does not produce the desired result, the service request is then routed for an ad hoc fulfilment. Ad hoc fulfilment is an exception and should be treated like one. A decision should be made about whether to act upon the exception or simply deny the service request fulfilment. This decision is usually defined by the model and the way the model handles exceptions. Regardless of the decision made, details of a case should become an input into the	

service request model review and optimization process, so that this case is well-defined and added to the model, or additional checks are added to triage and categorization, to sort such cases out of the model.

Fulfilment review	Service request fulfilment is checked according to the model.
	The fulfilment review should be described by the model. The fulfilment review may contain some procedures to check to what extent the fulfilment has produced the desired result.
	The fulfilment review may also involve collecting user feedback and measuring user satisfaction.
	The reports and record of the fulfilment review serve as inputs into the service request review and optimization process.

3.2.2 Service request review and optimization

The process is focused on the continual improvement of the service request models management practice. It is recommended to perform this process regularly or when triggered by the user survey results. This process includes the activities listed in Table 3.3 and transforms the inputs into outputs.

Table 3.3 Inputs, activities, and outputs of the service request review and optimization process

Key inputs	Activities	Key outputs
Current service request models	Service request records and reports analysis	Updated service request model
User survey results	Service request model improvement initiation	Updated service request procedures and working instructions
Related changes and change models	Service request model update communication	
Policies and regulatory requirements		
Service catalogue		
Service level agreements		
IT asset information		
CMDB		
Capacity and performance information		

Figure 3.3 shows a workflow diagram of the process.

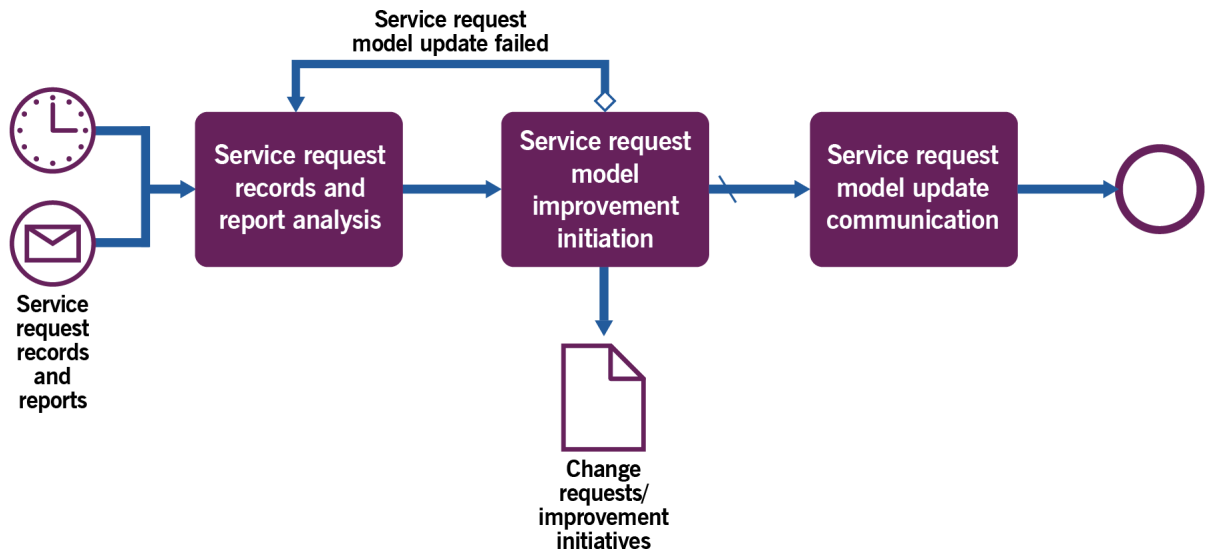


Figure 3.3 Workflow of the service request review and optimization process

Table 3.4 provides a description of the process activities.

Table 3.4 Activities of the service request review and optimization process

Activity	Description
Service request records and reports analysis	The service request practice owner, together with the service owners and other relevant stakeholders, perform a review of the selected service requests and related metrics over the period and/or relevant repeating changes from the change enablement practice. They identify opportunities for the new service request models and/or improvement of the current service request models.
Service request model improvement initiation	The service request practice owner registers the improvement initiatives, which are submitted for processing with the involvement of the continual improvement practice and/or change requests. If testing does not confirm the effectiveness of the proposed service request model, it is returned for further analysis.
Service request model update communication	If the service request model is successfully updated, it is communicated to the relevant stakeholders. This is usually done by the service request practice owner or the service owner.

4 Organizations and people

4.1 ROLES, COMPETENCIES, AND RESPONSIBILITIES

The practice guides do not describe the practice management roles such as practice owner, practice lead, or practice coach. They focus instead on specialist roles that are specific to each practice. The structure and naming of each role may differ from organization to organization, so any roles defined in ITIL should not be treated as mandatory, or even recommended. Remember, roles are not job titles. One person can take on multiple roles and one role can be assigned to multiple people.

Roles are described in the context of processes and activities. Each role is characterized by a competency profile based on the model shown in Table 4.1.

Table 4.1 Competency codes and profiles

Competency code	Competency profile (activities and skills)
L	<u>Leader</u> Decision-making, delegating, overseeing other activities, providing incentives and motivation, and evaluating outcomes
A	<u>Administrator</u> Assigning and prioritizing tasks, record-keeping, ongoing reporting, and initiating basic improvement
C	<u>Coordinator/communicator</u> Coordinating multiple parties, maintaining communication between stakeholders, and running awareness campaigns
M	<u>Methods and techniques expert</u> Designing and implementing work techniques, documenting procedures, consulting on processes, work analysis, and continual improvement
T	<u>Technical expert</u> Providing technical (IT) expertise and conducting expertise-based assignments

There are no specialist roles specific to the service request management practice. The role of request initiator can be fulfilled by any user or authorized user representative; it does not require special skills or competencies. The key activities of the service processes described above are typically performed by the service provider's technical specialists, service owners, and user support agents, but there are no or little competency profile specific to the practice.

Examples of other roles which can be involved in the service request management activities are listed in Table 4.2, together with the associated competency profiles and specific skills.

Table 4.2 Examples of the roles involved in service request management practice activities

Activity	Responsible roles	Competency profile	Specific skills
Service request fulfilment control process			
Request categorization	User support agent	CTM	Good knowledge of the organization's products and services
	Product owner		
	Service owner		

	Technical specialist		Knowledge of service catalogue, SLAs, request models
Service request model initiation and control	User support agent Service owner Technical specialist	CAT	Good knowledge of the service request models and of the service provider organization
Ad hoc fulfilment control	Service owner Technical team lead	CTA	Good knowledge of products, services, and SLAs Understanding of business needs Authority to assign resources and plan ad hoc work
Fulfilment review	Service owner Practice owner Practice manager/ coordinator	MCT	Good knowledge of products, services, and SLAs Understanding of business needs Good knowledge of the service request models and of the service provider organization
Service request and review optimization			
Service request records and reports analysis	Product owner Service owner Practice owner Practice manager/ coordinator	TM	Good knowledge of the service and products and service request models
Service request model improvement initiation	Practice owner Practice manager/ coordinator Product owner Service owner Resource owner ITSM tool consultant	TCA	Good knowledge of the service, products, and service request models Good knowledge of available tools and methods
Service request model update communication	Practice owner Practice manager/ coordinator	C	Understanding the service request models Communication skills

Product owner

Service owner

Resource owner

4.2 ORGANIZATIONAL STRUCTURES AND TEAMS

It is unusual to see dedicated organizational structures for the service request management practice. This practice is integrated in the day-to-day activities of the service delivery and realization team or technicians that are defined in advance during the service request model definition. Usually, the same team structures are used for service request management as for the incident management practice. However, in situations where services include service request as part of the service utility, and demand is very high, dedicated teams can be formed to process and fulfil all or some types of service requests. In many cases, automation can decrease the need for such teams and improve service quality.

5 Information and technology

5.1 INFORMATION EXCHANGE

The effectiveness of service request management practice is based on the quality of the information used. This information includes, but is not limited to, information about:

- customers and users
- services and their associated request catalogue and request models
- partners and suppliers, including information on the services they provide
- policies and requirements which regulate service provision
- stakeholder satisfaction with the practice.

This information may take various forms. The key inputs and outputs of the practice are listed in the value streams and processes section of this guide.

5.2 AUTOMATION AND TOOLING

In some cases, the work of the service request management practice can benefit significantly from automation. Where this is possible and effective, it may involve the solutions outlined in Table 5.1.

Table 5.1 Automation solutions for service request management activities

Process activity	Means of automation	Key functionality	Impact on the effectiveness of the practice
Service request fulfilment control			
Request categorization	Workflow management and collaboration tools	Request catalogue management	High
	ITSM toolsets	Work assignment	
		Pre-defined routing	
Service request model initiation and control	Workflow management and collaboration tools	Work assignment	High
	ITSM toolsets	Predefined routing	
		Collaboration, task	
Ad hoc fulfilment control	Workflow management and collaboration tools	Monitoring work progress	Medium to high
	ITSM toolsets	Communications	
	System monitoring tools	Notifications, escalation	
Fulfilment review	Workflow management and collaboration tools	Communication and collaboration	Medium
	ITSM toolsets	Reporting and analytics	
Service request and review optimization			
Service request records and reports analysis	Analysis and reporting tools	Statistical analysis of service request workloads and flows	High

Service request model improvement initiation	Workflow management and collaboration tools	Backlog and workflow management and visualization	Medium to high
		Communication and collaboration	
Service request model update communication	Publishing tools	Mail	High
	Social media	Push notifications	
	Workflow management tools	Web portal	
		Awareness posts	

6 Partners and suppliers

Very few services are delivered using only an organization's own resources. Most, if not all, depend on other services, often provided by third parties outside the organization (see section 2.4 of *ITIL Foundation: ITIL 4 Edition* for a model of a service relationship). Relationships and dependencies introduced by supporting services are described in the practice guides for service design, architecture management, and supplier management.

Due to the intrinsic characteristics of the service requests, such as being predefined, pre-approved, and predictable, it is natural for organizations to outsource the service request management. Organizations should be careful in keeping the level of the service request management high, as it has a direct impact on the users' satisfaction and may have an undesirable impact on the value of the service.

Service request models should define how third parties are involved in service request fulfilment and how the organization ensures effective collaboration. This will depend on the architecture and design solutions for products, services, and value streams. Nonetheless, the optimization of service request models supporting these solutions will involve the service request management practice.

Defined standard interfaces may become an easy way to communicate conditions and requirements in order for a supplier to become a part of the organization's ecosystem. Such an interface description may include rules of data exchange, tools, and processes that will create a common language in the multi-vendor environment.

Where organizations aim to ensure a fast and effective service request management practice, they usually try to agree to close cooperation with their partners and suppliers, removing formal bureaucratic barriers in communication, collaboration, and decision-making (see the supplier management practice guide for more information).

7 Important reminder

Most of the content of the practice guides should be taken as a suggestion of areas that an organization might consider when establishing and nurturing their own practices. The practice guides are catalogues of topics that organizations might think about, not a list of answers. When using the content of the practice guides, organizations should always follow the ITIL guiding principles:

- focus on value
- start where you are
- progress iteratively with feedback
- collaborate and promote visibility
- think and work holistically
- keep it simple and practical
- optimize and automate.

More information on the guiding principles and their application can be found in section 4.3 of *ITIL Foundation: ITIL 4 Edition*.

8 Acknowledgments

AXELOS Ltd is grateful to everyone who has contributed to the development of this guidance. These practice guides incorporate an unprecedented level of enthusiasm and feedback from across the ITIL community. In particular, AXELOS would like to thank the following people.

8.1 AUTHORS

Miroslav Hlohovsky, Don Page, Robert Pinnington.

8.2 REVIEWERS

Dinara Adyrbayeva, Cheryl Grimes, Roman Jouravlev, Georges Kemmerling, Henny Kerkvliet, Niels Loader, Anton Lykov, Paulo Tourinho.

